door to Chinese and Indian pushes for broader ties with Iran. The shelving of the Iran nuclear issue via the JCPOA and the consequent lifting of international and many unilateral US sanctions against Iran opened the way for both Beijing and New Delhi to work to strengthen their respective ties with Iran. Previously both Beijing and New Delhi restrained their partnerships with Iran for the sake of avoiding American wrath and sanctions. Chinese and Indian moves toward Iran were sharply constrained by US pressure and consequent Chinese and Indian limitation or moves toward Iran.

Second, the emergence since 2009 of China as a significant naval power in the Indian Ocean has intensified India's apprehension of creeping encirclement by China and by extension Sino–Iranian cooperation. So too has the intensified Chinese courtship of countries around the Indian Ocean littoral since Xi Jin-ping's promulgation of the BRI. Beijing now needs regional partners willing to host Indian Ocean facilities integral to Beijing's Maritime Silk Road proposals and willing to provide politically reliable support for PLAN ships operating in the Arabian Sea. Iran offers China very promising cooperation in both regards. Both Chinese and Indian calculations in this regard are linked to deeply rooted views of their respective trajectories of national rise. Beijing sees its emergence as a SA-IOR power (gradually and incrementally over time) as an essential stepping stone for its primacy in Asia. New Delhi, on the other hand, seeks to uphold what it views as India's traditional primacy in the Indian Ocean and fears that China's steady advance is eroding India's primacy. This erosion of India's regional primacy diminishes India's national security and undercuts the critical geopolitical basis for India's emergence as a world power. An Iranian tilt toward Beijing or toward New Delhi would be a significant factor in the relative standing of New Delhi and Beijing on the Asian stage.

A third factor underpinning the new Sino–Indian rivalry toward Iran is Iran's own imperial ambition. Iran too aspires